■ THE DAILY GOODS STORY SCOUT - Thursday, September 24, 2026

TODAY'S RUNDOWN SLOTS

THE LIST (5 stories)

■ *Insidious checkout trick costing California's convenience store shoppers triple the advertised price*

The Angle: *It's the kind of story that makes everyone want to go dig an old receipt out of their car - a checkout scam quietly tripling prices at one of the biggest convenience chains in the country, and it's happening in the most populous state in the U.S.*

- The scam is showing up at **7-Eleven** stores across **California**
- Shoppers are reportedly being charged up to **triple** the advertised shelf price at checkout
- The advice: **double-check your receipt** before you walk out the door

The Receipt Check Challenge

- Have you ever caught a store overcharging you at checkout - and did you say something or just eat the cost?

nypost.com (Tier 1) | Score: 86/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 29 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://nypost.com/2026/09/24/us-news/california-7-11-stores-caught-charging-shoppers-more-than-advertised/

■ *'The Traitors: New Blood' Sends 3 More Players Home In Shocking Double-Episode Bloodbath*

The Angle: *A double-episode elimination on one of TV's most-talked-about reality shows always sends fans into a frenzy online, and a three-person wipeout in one go is rare enough to be real watercooler talk today.*

The Debate Starter

- Are you Team Traitor or Team Faithful — call in and tell us who you think should've gone home instead.

nypost.com (Tier 1) | Score: 86/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 29 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://decider.com/2026/09/24/who-went-home-on-the-traitors-new-blood-this-week/

■■ *Germany has completed the world's tallest series produced onshore wind turbine, standing 285 metres tall with a 199 metre hub. Its 7.2 MW capacity is expected to generate 17–18 million kWh a year, helping its owner produce about two thirds of its electricity from renewables.*

The Angle: *It's a literal skyscraper spinning out clean power - a record-breaking feat of engineering that gives hosts an easy "how big is that, really" comparison moment while tapping into the bigger renewable energy conversation.*

- Stands **285 metres tall** - that's taller than most skyscrapers
- Hub height alone is **199 metres**
- Rated at **7.2 MW**, expected to crank out **17-18 million kWh a year**
- Its owner now gets roughly **two-thirds** of its electricity from renewables

The Scale Check

- Ask listeners to guess how many football fields tall 285 metres actually is before you tell them (it's about three).

Reddit r/upliftingnews (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.max-boegl.de/en/news/world-record-hub-height-max-boegl-and-vestas-complete-wind-energy-project-with-the-tallest-serial-produced-wind-tower.html

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■ *McDonald's unveils $8.5 billion tech plan to fend off Burger King*

The Angle: *This isn't just a burger fight anymore - it's Big Macs vs. Whoppers going full Silicon Valley, and an $8.5 billion number is the kind of flex that gets everyone asking what fast food even looks like in five years.*

- **McDonald's** is reportedly rolling out a massive **$8.5 billion** tech investment plan.
- The move is being framed as a direct shot at rival **Burger King** in the fast food wars.
- The scale of the spend signals this is about more than kiosks and apps - it's a bet on tech as the new battleground for drive-thru dominance.

The Debate Starter

- Would you actually notice $8.5 billion in 'tech upgrades' next time you're in the drive-thru, or is this just corporate chest-thumping?

Reddit r/technology (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://qz.com/mcdonalds-investor-day-next-strategy-restaurant-overhaul-092326

■ *If Trump bans U.S. diesel exports, global prices will go even higher, experts say*

The Angle: *Diesel prices touch everything from trucking to home heating, so a U.S. export ban aimed at helping Americans could actually spike costs everywhere, including at home — a classic case of a policy possibly doing the opposite of what it promises.*

- **Trump** is reportedly considering a ban on **U.S. diesel exports**
- **Experts** warn the move would push **global diesel prices** even higher, not lower

The Debate Starter

- Would you trust a 'keep prices down' policy that experts say could actually jack them up worldwide?

www.cbc.ca (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.cbc.ca/news/business/us-diesel-export-ban-9.7357460?cmp=rss

Backup options:

■ *Trump considers banning export of U.S. diesel*

The Angle: *This is a real 'wait, what does that mean for MY gas station' story - diesel powers trucking, farming, and shipping, so any export ban talk moves prices fast and puts Trump's energy policy back in the headlines.*

The Wallet Check

- If it means cheaper diesel at home, are you here for it - or does 'keep it domestic' policy make you nervous?

CTV News (via Google News) (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://news.google.com/rss/articles/CBMilgFBVV95cUxNeFU1dWJ0UWkybERzcmFWcDFDcjU5cmV1MExoM3Mzb0ItVDdlTU9Ld0twRU1kb2FjMmF5OGdwOFdabF9qNTNpd3pEUGJ0bk9iXzhhV1p3SkFDTFZwUEoweFhuUkRvSXJzS1o1cFNMTlp4U1doXzRlRGVsaHNwWVM0bV9qVEFkcVprQVZGR3Y2V1k3UWh4VVE?oc=5

CANADIAN NEWS (3 stories)

■ *CEO who posted about wearing 'Lake America' sweatshirts to Halifax is no longer CEO*

The Angle: *A Canadian company's top exec is out of a job after a viral post showing off 'Lake America' sweatshirts on a Halifax trip - the kind of petty-nationalism jab that's been everywhere since the Trump 'Gulf of America' rebrand, except this one may have cost someone their career.*

The Debate Starter

- Should a CEO get fired for a joke that plays great with customers but embarrasses the board?

Reddit r/canada (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.cbc.ca/news/canada/lake-america-sweatshirts-halifax-9.7356629

■■ *More than two in three Canadians back EU associate membership: poll*

The Angle: *A new poll finds a solid majority of Canadians would back some kind of formal tie-up with the European Union — worth talking about given how much noise there's been lately about Canada rethinking its reliance on the US.*

- Poll finds **more than 2 in 3 Canadians** support the idea of **EU associate membership**
- Story is generating buzz on **Reddit's r/canada**
- Comes amid broader chatter about Canada diversifying its international alliances

The Debate Starter

- Would you actually want Canada tied closer to the EU — trade, travel, maybe even a shared passport lane — or is that a bridge too far?

Reddit r/canada (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://toronto.citynews.ca/2026/09/24/more-than-two-in-three-canadians-back-eu-associate-membership-poll/

■■ *Carney's comments over possibility of U.S. invasion reveal how contingency plans are always in place*

The Angle: *It sounds like a wild headline, but it's really a window into how governments quietly plan for every scenario - even ones involving your closest ally. Given the recent friction in U.S.-Canada relations, this comment is going to get people talking about just how seriously Ottawa takes the idea.*

- **Prime Minister Mark Carney** publicly addressed the idea of a possible **U.S. invasion** of Canada.
- He pointed to it as proof that **contingency plans** exist for virtually any scenario, no matter how far-fetched it sounds.

The Debate Starter

- Does it freak you out that there's literally a plan on the shelf for a U.S. invasion, or does it just prove Ottawa's doing its homework?

www.cbc.ca (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.cbc.ca/news/politics/canada-us-trump-carney-invasion-plans-9.7357842?cmp=rss

Backup options:

■ *Brave 12-year-old fought off angry black mama bear in his backyard: 'It was fight or die'*

The Angle: *A kid says it was literally 'fight or die' against a black bear near his Canadian backyard - a wild survival story with a happy ending that's tailor-made for water-cooler talk.*

- **Westgate**, just **12 years old**, describes the encounter bluntly: **'It was fight or die.'**
- He lives near the **Canadian border**, in an area where black bears are a regular presence in the neighborhood.
- He'd already been taught what to do if he ever ran into a bear in real life - and had to put that training to the test.

The Phone-In Trigger

- Would your kid know what to do if a bear showed up in the backyard?

nypost.com (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://nypost.com/2026/09/24/us-news/brave-12-year-old-fought-off-angry-black-mama-bear-in-his-backyard-it-was-fight-or-die/

■■ *Elections Quebec sets limits on use of English at polling stations*

The Angle: *Quebec's language politics are always a live wire, and putting new limits on English at polling stations reignites the francophone-anglophone divide right as election season chatter heats up.*

- **Elections Quebec**, the province's official election authority, is putting new limits on the use of **English at polling stations**.
- The move plugs into Quebec's long-running push to protect and prioritize the **French language** in public institutions.
- Exact details of the new rules haven't been reported yet — just that English use is being restricted at voting sites.

The Debate Starter

- Fair language protection or a step too far for English-speaking voters — where do you land?

CTV News (via Google News) (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://news.google.com/rss/articles/CBMitAFBVV95cUxQc1czVEpIclk3cXlHYm1CdVo3SXh1bU5sdnlLYTRoZ3AzLTFBaVBxZjBxWVdCMU1RWkphZU80ZF9renNPdDZEVlNQQm1taC1aT3BpR3NBOEZCWDBVZXpfOHVhcmRFMVNhUnJza3ZWOEVLZjRZN1pKZ2xxTVhPRmlJR0t1bXQ1WEhpNHhETmhtaGtfN19ROFhnSDhXX2ZSQXdFeGRkUC0yNW9NQ1ZEZjVKbW9TRTI?oc=5

ENTERTAINMENT (4 stories)

■ *AI 'actor' Tilly Norwood glitches during Piers Morgan interview, starts speaking Cantonese*

The Angle: *Tilly Norwood, the AI-generated 'actress' that already had Hollywood in a panic over AI replacing real performers, just glitched out mid-interview — the kind of uncanny-valley moment that's basically a live commercial for why people don't trust this stuff yet.*

- **Tilly Norwood**, the AI-generated 'actress,' reportedly glitched during a live interview with **Piers Morgan**
- Mid-interview, the AI abruptly started speaking **Cantonese** with no explanation
- Story is making rounds on **r/nottheonion** — the subreddit for stuff so absurd it sounds fake

The Debate Starter

- Would you ever trust an AI 'actor' again after watching it randomly short-circuit into another language live on camera?

Reddit r/nottheonion (Tier 1) | Score: 82/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 25 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.cbc.ca/news/entertainment/tilly-norwood-glitches-piers-morgan-switches-language-speaks-cantonese-9.7352222

■ *Law Roach dishes on Zendaya’s surprising reaction to him revealing she’d secretly married Tom Holland*

The Angle: *Zendaya's longtime stylist let a huge secret slip on a red carpet, and now he's dishing on how she actually reacted — that's the kind of behind-the-scenes drama that gets people talking.*

- **Law Roach**, Zendaya's go-to stylist, revealed on a red carpet that she and **Tom Holland** were already secretly married.
- The slip happened at the **2026 Actor Awards** back in March.
- Roach is now speaking out about **Zendaya's reaction** to him accidentally spilling the news.

The Oops Factor

- Honest slip-up or a wink-wink way of confirming the secret without technically 'announcing' it?

pagesix.com (Tier 2) | Score: 82/90 (45 fit + 8 source + 29 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://pagesix.com/2026/09/24/celebrity-news/law-roach-shares-how-zendaya-reacted-after-he-revealed-shed-secretly-married-tom-holland/

■ *Law Roach Admits He Lies About Zendaya’s ‘Business’ to Protect Her Privacy: ‘You Don’t Have the Right’*

The Angle: *Law Roach isn't just Zendaya's stylist — he's practically a co-star at this point, so hearing him openly cop to feeding the media misdirection is a rare, honest peek behind the celebrity PR curtain.*

- **Law Roach**, Zendaya's longtime stylist, admits he lies about her "business" on purpose.
- His justification, in his own words: **"You don't have the right."**

- The comment frames it as a deliberate privacy tactic, not an accident or slip-up.

The Debate Starter

- Do celebrities owe the public the truth, or is spin control a fair form of self-defense?

Reddit r/entertainment (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://people.com/law-roach-lies-to-protect-zendaya-privacy-tom-holland-marriage-12138167?utm_campaign=peoplemagazine&utm_medium=social&utm_source=reddit.com&utm_content=post

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■ *Yankees playoff rotation still in flux — and Cam Schlittler may not start Game 1*

The Angle: *The Yankees are heading into the playoffs without a set pitching plan, and the guy who looked like their breakout arm might get passed over for Game 1 — that's the kind of last-minute drama that gets fans and hosts arguing before the first pitch.*

- **Cam Schlittler** made his final regular-season start on **Thursday night**
- The **Yankees'** wild-card series opens **Tuesday**
- Manager hasn't locked in who starts **Game 1**

The Debate Starter

- Would you trust the hot rookie arm or a proven vet to open a win-or-go-home series?

nypost.com (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://nypost.com/2026/09/24/sports/yankees-playoff-rotation-still-in-flux-and-cam-schlittler-may-not-start-game-1/

Backup options:

■ *Roseanne Barr eviscerates sitcom co-star for confronting her about racist tweets: 'Stay f–ked' - Page Six*

The Angle: *A sitcom family feud gone nuclear years after the scandal that ended Roseanne's career — the kind of celebrity trainwreck that's pure watercooler gold.*

- **Roseanne Barr** unloaded on former on-screen son **Michael Fishman** after he spoke out about her **2018 racism controversy**
- She called him a **"brainwashed bigot"**
- Barr's rant included the line: **"He f■king doesn't even f■king know what I said"**
- The blowup happened last month, resurfacing the tweet scandal that got her fired from **"Roseanne"**

The Debate Starter

- Should castmates ever be expected to publicly denounce a colleague years after a scandal, or is Fishman just stirring up old drama?

Page Six (via NewsAPI) (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://pagesix.com/2026/09/23/entertainment/roseanne-barr-eviscerates-sitcom-co-star-for-confronting-her-about-racist-tweets/

■ *Disney+ and Hulu raise prices by up to 13 percent after doubling profits - Ars Technica*

The Angle: *Disney+ and Hulu are hiking prices up to 13% right after Disney posted doubled streaming profits - so viewers get to foot the bill for a win the company already had. It's the latest gut-punch in the streaming price creep everyone's grumbling about.*

- The **Disney+ ad-free plan** is now pricier than **Netflix's** equivalent tier.
- Price hikes are landing across **Disney+** and **Hulu**, up to **13%**.
- The increases come right after Disney's streaming business **doubled its profits**.

The Debate Starter

- Are you canceling a streaming service this year, or have you just accepted the price creep?

Ars Technica (via NewsAPI) (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://arstechnica.com/gadgets/2026/09/disney-and-hulu-raise-prices-by-up-to-13-percent-after-doubling-profits/

■ *Robert Pattinson Says ‘The Batman: Part II’ Is “a Different Take on a Batman Movie”: “So Ambitious” - The Hollywood Reporter*

The Angle: *The Batman was a three-hour noir detective story that broke box office records, so when the guy under the cowl says the sequel is a totally different animal, that's instant fan bait.*

- **Robert Pattinson** told **Collider** that *The Batman: Part II* is "**a real left turn from the first**" movie.
- He described the sequel as "**so ambitious**," per **The Hollywood Reporter**.
- The follow-up to 2022's *The Batman* is set for release in **2027**.
- Pattinson says even he's excited to see how the next film **turns out**.

The Debate Starter

- The first one was basically a goth detective movie — what's left for a "left turn" that doesn't just mean weirder?

Hollywood Reporter (via NewsAPI) (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: http://www.hollywoodreporter.com/movies/movie-news/robert-pattinson-the-batman-2-different-take-1236708702/

■ *‘Ted Lasso’ Emotionally Charged Episode Brings a Return to Form for Series - The Hollywood Reporter*

The Angle: *After a season fans said felt flat, episode 8 lands the emotional gut-punch the show built its name on — this is the one that has critics saying Season 4 is finally clicking.*

- The episode is titled **"Follow the Anger"** — episode 8 of **Season 4**.
- Three separate storylines collide: **Gemma's injury**, **Alice's breakdown**, and **Roy's confession**.
- Critics are calling it a **"return to form"** for the series after a season some felt was missing that classic emotional punch.

The Debate Starter

- Did Season 4 lose you before this episode pulled you back in?

Hollywood Reporter (via NewsAPI) (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: http://www.hollywoodreporter.com/tv/tv-features/ted-lasso-season-four-episode-eight-recap-1236708579/

TRENDING TODAY

🛩■ *Beach battle erupts as classic California event faces closure over green backlash*

The Angle: *A beloved, decades-old California beach tradition is suddenly on the chopping block because its dates collide with bird nesting season — it's the classic "tradition vs. environment" fight that always gets people fired up.*

- A long-running **beach airshow** in California is facing calls for **closure or cancellation**.
- The pushback centers on timing — the event lands right in the middle of the **birds' incubation period**.
- Critics warn the noise and low flybys could disturb **active nests** on the beach.
- It's shaping up as a fight between a **"classic" local institution** and environmental advocates.

The Debate Starter

- Do you ground a beloved tradition to protect a few nests, or let the birds fend for themselves for one weekend a year?

nypost.com (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://nypost.com/2026/09/24/us-news/huntington-beach-turtle-nests-spark-petition-to-postpone-pacific-airshow/

Backup options:

■■ *Exclusive | Chatter around CNN deal says Kara Swisher is quitting over ex Nellie Bowles - Page Six*

The Angle: *A big-name tech journalist walking away from a major network is newsy on its own, but the whisper that her ex-girlfriend factors in turns this into pure watercooler gossip — and it's dropping right as CNN's ownership is in upheaval.*

- **Kara Swisher** announced on her **"Pivot"** podcast Tuesday that she's asked her agent to get her out of her **CNN** contract
- Her deal officially doesn't end until **the end of 2026** — she wants out early
- The timing lines up with news that **David Ellison's Paramount Skydance** is expected to make moves affecting CNN
- Page Six is floating a juicier theory: her exit may be tangled up with her ex, **Nellie Bowles**

The Gossip Angle

- Is this a principled exit over network politics, or a messier personal story dressed up as a business decision?

Page Six (via NewsAPI) (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://pagesix.com/2026/09/23/society/chatter-around-cnn-deal-says-kara-swisher-is-quitting-over-ex-nellie-bowles/

LIFESTYLE CHAT

■ *Salmon Are Thriving After Klamath River Dam Removals, Study Finds*

The Angle: *Salmon Are Thriving After Klamath River Dam Removals, Study Finds*

Reddit r/upliftingnews (Tier 1) | Score: 86/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 29 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.nytimes.com/2026/09/24/climate/klamath-salmon-recovery-dam-removal.html?smid=re-share

Backup options:

■ *Just one small serving of ultra-processed food a day linked to higher disease risk, major study finds - foxnews.com*

The Angle: *This isn't about giving up junk food entirely - it's about how little it takes to move the needle on real disease risk, which makes it an instant guilt-trip conversation starter for anyone who eats processed snacks daily.*

- Researchers tracked nearly **8.8 million adults** for this analysis.
- Every extra **100 grams** of ultra-processed food a day was linked to higher disease risk.
- That's roughly **3½ ounces** - basically one small snack or packaged item.
- The risks tied to that daily habit include **cardiovascular disease** and **cancer**.
- Study was published **Sept. 22** in the journal *Fa[…]* (per Fox News).

The Guilt Check

- Be honest - how many ultra-processed snacks did you already eat today?

Fox News (via NewsAPI) (Tier 1) | Score: 81/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 24 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.foxnews.com/food-drink/just-one-small-serving-ultra-processed-food-day-linked-higher-disease-risk-major-study-finds

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■ *A former Memphis hotel has been transformed into 110 permanent homes for veterans who experienced homelessness, replacing temporary shelter with stable housing and access to mental health care, recovery services, job training, education and other support.*

The Angle: *A former Memphis hotel has been transformed into 110 permanent homes for veterans who experienced homelessness, replacing temporary shelter with stable housing and access to mental health care, recovery services, job training, education and other support.*

Reddit r/upliftingnews (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://hoodline.com/2026/08/former-memphis-hotel-reborn-as-110-permanent-homes-for-homeless-veterans/

CLOSER: THE KICKER/GOODBYES (franchise fallback)

■ *Two beavers released in Dorset, England transformed a patch of woodland into a thriving wetland in just one year, building a 115-foot dam that created a pond where otters fish and barn owls hunt. The wetland is still holding water despite the 2026 drought.*

The Angle: *It's the ultimate 'let nature do its thing' story - two beavers dropped into a random patch of English woodland went full contractor mode and built an entire wetland ecosystem in one year, no permits required.*

- Just **two beavers** were released into woodland in **Dorset, England**
- They built a **115-foot dam**, creating a brand new pond
- The pond now draws **otters** fishing and **barn owls** hunting
- The wetland is **still holding water** even through the **2026 drought**

The Feel-Good Wrap

- Two beavers out-engineered a drought - humble brag for the animal kingdom.

Reddit r/upliftingnews (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.ecoticias.com/en/two-beavers-released-in-dorset-built-a-115-foot-dam-in-a-single-year-and-turned-a-shaded-wood-into-a-wetland-where-an-otter-fishes-and-a-barn-owl-hunts-and-the-dam-is-still-holding-water-through-the-d/37220/

Backup options:

■■ *Drilling begins at 'real site' of Noah's Ark as activists warn 'Darwinism will be dismantled'*

The Angle: *A boat-shaped rock formation in Turkey has believers convinced it's the actual Ark, and now excavation crews are literally drilling into it hoping to knock out Darwin once and for all - it's the kind of headline that sounds fake but isn't.*

- Excavation has reportedly begun at the **Durup■nar site**, a formation long claimed by some to be the **'real' Noah's Ark**
- Activists behind the dig say the findings could **'dismantle Darwinism'**
- Story is trending out of **r/nottheonion** - the internet's go-to feed for real news that reads like satire

The Debate Starter

- Is this bold science-vs-faith investigation or just a rock getting way too much funding?

Reddit r/nottheonion (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.joe.co.uk/news/noahs-ark-site-turkey-drilling-researchers-evidence-549016

FLEX (cap check: THE GREAT DEBATE 1/5 this month; TECH TALK 3/3 this month; Advice/Relationship Cluster 4/3 this month)

(no flex-slot candidates cleared the cap/score bar today)

ADDITIONAL CANDIDATES (no specific segment match, but scored well on source/quality - producer's call on where these fit)

■ *Florida is turning roadside land into monarch butterfly habitat, with researchers planting up to 15,000 native milkweeds through 2029. Monarchs are already using some of the new plants, transforming overlooked highway land into feeding and breeding habitat.*

The Angle: *It's the kind of good-news story that gives listeners a little hope - Florida is literally planting milkweed along roadsides to save monarch butterflies, and it's already working.*

- Researchers are planting up to **15,000 native milkweeds** along Florida roadsides

- The project runs through **2029**
- Monarchs are already showing up and using the new plants to feed and breed
- The habitat is being built on land that was previously just overlooked highway shoulder

The Feel-Good Follow-Up

- Would you want your city planting butterfly gardens along the highway instead of just mowing grass?

Reddit r/upliftingnews (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.ecoticias.com/en/florida-roadside-milkweeds-monarch-butterflies/37075/

■■ *Mystery men emerge from New York City sewers near Benjamin Netanyahu's hotel*

The Angle: *It's got everything a good lifestyile chat needs — a weird visual, a security mystery, and a big name attached, so it's basically tailor-made for a 'what were they actually doing down there' debate.*

- Story comes out of **r/nottheonion**, centered on **New York City**
- Unidentified men reportedly climbed up **from the sewers** right by **Benjamin Netanyahu's** NYC hotel
- No official explanation given in the source — just the visual of guys emerging from underground near a high-security target

The Conspiracy Corner

- Secret Service sweep, utility workers, or something way weirder — what's your best theory for what those guys were doing down there?

ON-AIR BIT BREAKDOWN

- **Step 1: Pitch Your Theory** - 30 seconds each host -> Each host gives their gut theory for what the 'mystery men' were doing in the sewer — security check, urban explorers, conspiracy angle, whatever.
- **Step 2: Phone-a-Friend** - Open the lines -> Take a caller or two with their own wildest guess for the sewer mystery.
- **Step 3: Vote It Out** - Quick wrap -> Hosts pick the most believable theory on air and challenge listeners to text in if they've got inside info.

Reddit r/nottheonion (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.nbcnews.com/news/us-news/mystery-men-emerge-new-york-city-sewers-benjamin-netanyahus-hotel-rcna599492

■ *Tommy Tuberville Claims ‘Many’ Pilots, Flight Attendants Are Furries*

The Angle: *Tommy Tuberville Claims ‘Many’ Pilots, Flight Attendants Are Furries*

Reddit r/nottheonion (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.newsweek.com/videos/tommy-tuberville-claims-many-pilots-flight-attendants-are-furries

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■ *US Jockey Club forces name change for horse called Austrian Painter after complaint it was Nazi slang for Adolf Hitler*

The Angle: *A horse named "Austrian Painter" sounds harmless until you remember who else was an Austrian painter - The Jockey Club agreed and made the owner change it, and the absurdity of that sentence alone is a two-minute goodbye segment.*

- The horse was registered under the name **"Austrian Painter"**
- **The Jockey Club** (the body that approves official racehorse names in the US) stepped in after a complaint
- The complaint: it's reportedly used as **Nazi-era slang for Adolf Hitler**, who was, in fact, an Austrian painter before WWII
- The name was pulled and the horse was forced to be renamed

The Debate Starter

- Was this an obvious dog-whistle that needed catching, or did somebody way overthink a horse's name?

Reddit r/nottheonion (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.racingpost.com/news/international/us/us-jockey-club-forces-name-change-for-horse-called-austrian-painter-after-complaint-it-was-nazi-slang-for-adolf-hitler-a4Ii16W2hXIz/

BREAKOUT WATCH (below the show's usual engagement bar - included on editorial judgment, not metrics; producer's call)

❤■ *Firefighters build custom wheelchair ramp for woman after learning she had been trapped in her home for days after her previous ramp was stolen*

■ **Breakout potential** (editorial judgment, below the usual engagement bar): Injustice-then-redemption narrative (ramp stolen, woman trapped for days, firefighters step in) is a classic high-share emotional arc that outperforms typical feel-good posts.
The Angle: *A local fire crew didn't just answer the call, they came back and built her a custom wheelchair ramp after realizing she'd been stuck inside her own home for days. It's the kind of good-news story that restores your faith in humanity and always gets phones ringing.*

- A woman was reportedly **trapped inside her home for days** after her wheelchair ramp was **stolen**.
- Local **firefighters** learned about her situation and stepped in to help.
- The crew **built her a custom replacement ramp** so she could safely leave her house again.
- Story is circulating on **r/upliftingnews** as a feel-good moment amid heavier headlines.

The Feel-Good Phone-In

- Have you ever had someone completely unexpected show up and fix a problem you thought no one even noticed?

Reddit r/upliftingnews (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://patch.com/california/los-angeles/firefighters-build-wheelchair-ramp-after-thief-leaves-woman-trapped-home

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■ *China tightens controls on fentanyl-making chemicals shipped to the U.S. just days before Trump and Xi meet at the White House*

■ **Breakout potential** (editorial judgment, below the usual engagement bar): Direct timing tie-in to the Trump-Xi White House meeting gives this an immediate news-cycle hook that could get picked up by bigger outlets in the next 48 hours.
The Angle: *Fentanyl has been the defining U.S. public health crisis for years, and China tightening the chemical supply chain lands just days before Trump and Xi sit down face to face - the timing alone makes this a story.*

- **China** is tightening controls on chemicals used to manufacture **fentanyl** before they're shipped to the **U.S.**
- The move comes just days before **Trump** and **Xi** are set to meet at the **White House**
- Chinese-sourced precursor chemicals have long been blamed as a major driver of the U.S. fentanyl crisis

The Debate Starter

- Genuine crackdown or a calculated diplomatic gift timed to the Trump-Xi meeting?

Reddit r/upliftingnews (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://fortune.com/2026/09/22/china-xi-trump-fentanyl-precursor-drugs/?utm_source=reddit/

■ *Zelensky Says He Would Visit Moscow 'On a Rocket'*

■ **Breakout potential** (editorial judgment, below the usual engagement bar): A punchy, quotable Zelensky line ('on a rocket') from a recognizable global figure is exactly the kind of soundbite that gets clipped and spread independent of the underlying story.
The Angle: *A one-liner with teeth — Zelensky cracking jokes about rockets and Moscow is the kind of quote that's blunt, dark, and very on-brand for how he talks to the world right now.*

- **Zelensky** was asked about the idea of visiting **Moscow**
- His answer: he'd go **"on a rocket"**
- The line's landed as one of those quotes that's part joke, part warning — hence it trending on r/nottheonion

The Quote Reaction

- Is this Zelensky being savagely funny, or a line that's a little too dark to laugh at?

Reddit r/nottheonion (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.kyivpost.com/post/85331

■■ *Climbers are melting Everest's glacier with their urine, study warns*

■ **Breakout potential** (editorial judgment, below the usual engagement bar): The absurd, meme-ready premise (climbers' urine melting Everest's glacier) is a novel surprising-science angle tailor-made for nottheonion-style virality.
The Angle: *It sounds like satire, but researchers say the sheer volume of human waste left by climbers on Everest is speeding up glacial melt on the world's most famous mountain — a perfect blend of gross-out humor and real environmental stakes.*

- A new study warns that waste left behind by **climbers** is contributing to melting on **Everest's glacier**.
- The story's been flagged as a real-life "you can't make this up" headline, trending out of **r/nottheonion**.
- Everest sees hundreds of climbers a season, each leaving behind waste that's tough to remove at extreme altitude.

The Ick Factor

- Would knowing your bathroom break is melting a glacier change how you'd act on a bucket-list trip?

Reddit r/nottheonion (Tier 1) | Score: 53/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality - 25 penalty (used within the last 30 days)) -> STRONG

URL: https://www.the-independent.com/climate-change/news/mount-everest-glacier-melting-human-urine-b3043991.html

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■ *The AI Build-Out Is Becoming the Biggest Economic Bet in U.S. History*

■ **Breakout potential** (editorial judgment, below the usual engagement bar): Plugs directly into the ongoing 'is the AI buildout a bubble' discourse dominating tech/finance conversation right now, a trend with obvious cross-posting potential.
The Angle: *Data centers, chips, power grids — the AI buildout is being called the biggest economic wager in American history, and it's the kind of number so big it's almost hard to picture, which is exactly why it's got everyone talking.*

The Debate Starter

- Genius long-term bet or the next dot-com-style bubble waiting to pop?

Reddit r/technology (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.wsj.com/economy/the-ai-build-out-is-becoming-the-biggest-economic-bet-in-u-s-history-c60716dd?st=oT6MJ3&reflink=article_copyURL_share

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■ *Former soldier who shot at synagogue was suing military for $1M over vaccination policy*

■ **Breakout potential** (editorial judgment, below the usual engagement bar): The dark, surprising combination of a synagogue shooter and a vaccine-mandate lawsuit against the military hits two hot-button culture-war threads at once.
The Angle: *A former soldier tied to a synagogue shooting is now suing the Canadian military for $1 million over its COVID vaccine mandate - the kind of head-scratcher headline that makes you read it twice.*

- A **former Canadian Armed Forces member** is reportedly linked to shots fired at a **synagogue**
- The same individual is now **suing the military for $1 million**
- The lawsuit centers on the military's **COVID-19 vaccination policy**

The Head-Scratcher

- How does someone go from allegedly shooting at a synagogue to suing for a million bucks over a vaccine mandate?

Reddit r/canada (Tier 1) | Score: 58/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 11 quality - 10 penalty (Depressing/negative tone)) -> STRONG

URL: https://globalnews.ca/news/12070914/soldier-synagogue-suing-1-million-vaccination/

FRANCHISE BANK

WHAT THE FRIDAY: 4 banked (+15 each when found)
- "Tiny mouse brawl breaks out on London subway platform" (nypost.com, banked 2026-09-08)
- "Dramatic video shows naked man being pulled from East River by NYC cops" (nypost.com, banked 2026-09-09)
- "Lady wtf, your kid is right there!" (X/Twitter @WomenBeingAwful, banked 2026-09-16)
- "Channing Tatum addresses claims he trolled ex Zoë Kravitz online using burner account: ‘Wtf come on’" (Entertainment Weekly (via Google News), banked 2026-09-22)

THROWBACK THURSDAY: 19 banked (+15 each when found)
- "Here’s Why Fifth Harmony Fans Think the Girl Group Is Making a Comeback Ahead of Anniversary" (X/Twitter @Billboard, banked 2026-09-06)
- "Rachael Leigh Cook surprises fans at ‘Josie and the Pussycats’ 25th anniversary screening" (pagesix.com, banked 2026-09-07)
- "Stevie Wonder Announces ‘Songs in the Key of Life’ 50th Anniversary Tour https://t.co/trmKJsgwqb" (X/Twitter @Variety, banked 2026-09-08)
- "Michael Goodwin: Mamdani’s toxic Ground Zero blame game just latches on to still-open 9/11 wounds to boost himself" (nypost.com, banked 2026-09-08)
- "John Oliver to Host Comic Relief Live’s 40th Anniversary Show" (www.hollywoodreporter.com, banked 2026-09-09)
- "Where I was on 9/11: 4 people in N.L. share their stories of stepping up to help" (www.cbc.ca, banked 2026-09-11)
- "Gander mayor reflects on 25th anniversary of 9/11" (CTV News (via Google News), banked 2026-09-11)
- "Globe editorial: Nostalgia is no strategy for U.S. relations" (The Globe and Mail (via Google News), banked 2026-09-11)
- "Universal Studios Japan Celebrates Halloween With First R-Rated Attraction" (gizmodo.com, banked 2026-09-13)
- "‘Practical Magic 2’ Dazzles Up a Bit Of an Audience" (gizmodo.com, banked 2026-09-14)
- "The London revival of “Sunday in the Park With George” has been canceled following the exits of stars Ariana Grande and Jonathan Bailey." (X/Twitter @Variety, banked 2026-09-14)
- "'Sunday in the Park With George' London Revival Canceled After Ariana Grande, Jonathan Bailey Exits https://t.co/cPQ2IIvYql" (X/Twitter @Variety, banked 2026-09-14)
- "‘Sunday in the Park With George’ revival scrapped after Ariana Grande, Jonathan Bailey exits" (Entertainment Weekly (via Google News), banked 2026-09-14)
- "Margot Robbie stuns in a retro bikini as she joins shirtless Bradley Cooper to shoot the Ocean's Eleven 1960s prequel on the French Riviera" (www.dailymail.co.uk, banked 2026-09-16)
- "Here’s Why Fifth Harmony Fans Think the Girl Group Is Making a Comeback Ahead of Anniversary" (X/Twitter @Billboard, banked 2026-09-20)
- "NCT 127 Open 10th-Anniversary ‘Neo City: The Redline’ Tour With Sold-Out Seoul Run" (X/Twitter @Billboard, banked 2026-09-22)
- "1Retro adds cloud saves to RetroArch, OpenEmu, and other gaming platforms" (www.techspot.com, banked 2026-09-22)
- "NCT 127 Open 10th-Anniversary ‘Neo City: The Redline’ Tour With Sold-Out Seoul Run" (X/Twitter @Billboard, banked 2026-09-23)
- "‘The Visit’ at Pasadena Playhouse Review: The ’50s Absurdist Comedy Is Too Smug in Its Peak-Bleak View of Venal Humanity, but Jefferson Mays and Melinda Page Hamilton Are Worth the Visit" (variety.com, banked 2026-09-23)

SOURCES SKIPPED THIS RUN:

- @CBCNews (fetch failed)
- @Gizmodo (no posts cleared the 30+ likes bar - 5 below-bar candidate(s) considered for breakout potential)
- Morning Brew (OpenCLI browser-scrape returned nothing - check Chrome/bridge)
- 4 story(ies) removed after slotting (content-safety and/or not-significant-enough for THE LIST/TRENDING TODAY; automatically backfilled where possible; see run log)

Scout Report Generated: 2026-09-24 11:59 PM